

Communication Issue and Islam in Tahmima Anam's The Good Muslim: Contextual Analysis**Mutee Abdul Salaam Izadin al-Sarory****Assistant Professor (English language and literature) Department of Foreign Languages, Faculty of Arts and Humanities, Al-Baha University****(Received: 24-05-2025; Accepted: 31-08-2025)**

Abstract: Abstract: This paper attempts to approach one of the novel's The Good Muslim important issues, namely the communication issue between the novel's two main protagonists in relation to the impact of Islam upon it using the concept of the Islamic language (henceforth IL) as an analytical tool. Within the IL conceptualization, there are two IL dimensions: spiritual and worldly. There are also two contexts: the IL basic context (i.e. the Qur'an and Sunnah/Prophet's legacy) and the IL relational or fictive context (i.e., the novel's context). The analysis reveals that the IL worldly dimension is missing in the novel's context. Such an absence of an essential IL component covertly secludes the novel's main protagonists from each other. Consequently, the aforementioned communication reaches an impasse. With such negative impact of the missing IL fictive worldly dimension upon Islam itself as being immersed in spirituality, this paper suggests that appreciating literary works which incorporate IL as such, like The Good Muslim, from an Islamic perspective, would provide thought-provoking ideas about the extent of artistic fair treatment to, or biasness against, Islam.

Keywords: Islamic language (IL); fair treatment; biasness; contextualization.

عملية التواصل وصلتها بالإسلام في رواية المسلم الجيد للكاتبة تهيمية أنعم:
تحليل سياقي

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مستخلص البحث: تتناول هذه الورقة البحثية إحدى الأفكار الرئيسية في رواية "المسلم الجيد"، وهي عملية التواصل بين الشخصيات الرئيسية في الرواية ومدى علاقة الإسلام في التأثير عليها، باستخدام مفهوم اللغة الإسلامية كأداة تحليلية. ضمن هذا المفهوم، هناك بعدان: روحي وديني. كما يوجد سياقان: سياق أساسي (أي، القرآن والسنة) وسياق ارتباطي (سياق الرواية). يكشف التحليل أن البعد الديني للغة الإسلامية مفقود في سياق الرواية. هذا الغياب لعنصر أساسي من عناصر اللغة الإسلامية يعزل الشخصيات الرئيسية عن بعضها؛ وبغيابه تصل عملية التواصل إلى طريق مسدود بين الشخصيات. ونتيجة للتأثير السلبي لغياب البعد الديني على النظر للإسلام، تقترح الورقة أن تحليل الأعم ال الأدبية التي تتضمن اللغة الإسلامية، مثل رواية "المسلم الجيد"، من منظور إسلامي سيولد أفكاراً محفزة للتفكير حول التعامل مع الإسلام بعدل أو التحيز ضده في مثل تلك الأعمال الأدبية.

الكلمات مفتاحية: اللغة الإسلامية؛ عدل؛ تحيز؛ تأطير سياقي.



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1. Introduction

Despite the Islamic aspects in it, *The Good Muslim*, a novel by Tahmima Anam, has triggered many public reviews (consider, for instance, Hussein, 2011; Bidisha, 2011; Goodreads, 2011-2024) and received academic critiques from many non-Islamic perspectives such as war, gender, diaspora and identity discourses. Along with such critiques, there is a critique by Swazo (2018) that attempts to establish the idea that the Islamic background lurks beyond an irrational and incomprehensible fictional and non-fictional response alike to the Bangladeshi 1971 genocide backgrounded in the novel. Furthermore, it is hard to miss noticing that the novel's Islamic features constitute a main part of its structure without getting due critical attention from an Islamic perspective. For instance, consider the novel's main opening sections. Section 1, (named Book 1), specifically chapter 2, is introduced with the Qur'anic verse: "All that is in the Heavens and on Earth". Section 2, (entitled Book 2), specifically chapter 1, is labeled with this Qur'anic verse: "Every soul shall taste death". And Section 3, (called Book 3), specifically chapter 1, opens with the following Qur'anic verse: "God wrongs no one, Not even by the weight of an atom". These Qur'anic verses are parts of the following Qur'anic verses respectively: Surah Maryam, verse 93, Surah Aali Imran, verse 185, and Surah Al Nisaa' verse 40. All those parts of the Qur'anic verses are found out of their Qur'anic immediate contexts (i.e. verses) as well as general ones (i.e. Surahs). Those verses rough literal out-of-context interpretations are as follows respectively, "all creatures in the universe", "each person will die" and "God never does injustice to any human being" (The Qur'an). Despite incorporating those Qur'anic verses, in addition to many other Islamic aspects, in the novel's structure, this paper finds the existing critical literature about the novel, with their non-Islamic theorizations, unable to give the religious aspects (especially, the Islamic ones) their due signification within any fictive topical literary issue. Some studies would highlight the Islamic aspects as belonging to Islamic fanaticism. At best, some may consider them as social elements that need to be discursively comprehended within identity formation discourses.

Therefore, on its part, this paper argues that the novel, with its unambiguous Islamic features, calls for a contextual analysis—one that would provide a

different vision into the novel. More specifically, it sets to investigate the communication issue between the novel's main protagonists: Maya and Sohail, which apparently reaches a critical stage due to the impact of Sohail's conversion to Islam. At this juncture, it may be in order to provide a background about the Islamic language before showing how it is used as an analytical tool.

2. Islamic Language (IL)

The concept of the IL was first coined by al-Attas (1985:170) to denote the nature of the Islamic world languages such as Arabic, Malaysian, Urdu, etc. Those languages are believed to inherently carry the spirit of the Islamic worldview, at least as they are used in their present statuses. In other words, they manifest common basic vocabulary that represents the Islamic conceptual structures and semantic networks of the Islamic worldview. The IL is thus deeply incorporated in Muslims' speech and conception as it reflects the Islamic worldview in both its essential broad dimensions, that is, the spiritual and worldly aspects of life (al-Attas 1985: 170 & 2001: 30). This means that the worldview of Islam necessarily encompasses life in its entirety: this life and the Hereafter (al-Attas 2001: 1). Within this basic intrinsic broad picture, IL is actually a belief language, not an ordinary tool of communication. It is a spiritually and worldly powerful symbolic language in Islam.

The IL spiritual aspects are clearly demonstrated in the five pillars of Islam both linguistically and semantically: 1. Shahadah, (that is, witnessing that there is no god but God and that Mohammad is His Messenger), 2. Salat (i.e. Prayer), 3. Fasting, 4. Zakat (i.e. giving alms) and 5. Hajj (i.e. Pilgrimage). They are also essentially manifested in the six pillars of Islamic faith: Faith in 1. Allah, 2. His Angels, 3. His Books, 4. His Messengers, 5. The Hereafter, and 6. The Fate. There are also many expressions associated with those pillars that demonstrate the spiritual aspects of the IL such as 'In the name of Allah', 'By the grace of Allah', 'Peace be upon you', etc. In a Muslim's life, the connection with Allah (Subhanahu Wa Ta'ala, i.e., 'Glory to Him'; henceforth SWT) is not to be forgotten at all times. It is a matter of serious belief.

The worldly aspects of the IL can be realized in a Muslim's religious obligation to legally enforce and establish certain actions and practices in life so as

people's life affairs are maintained and protected in alignment with the justice that the IL basic context stipulates. The following worldly aspects are part and parcel of the IL; (the list is not exhaustive though): 1. Establishing justice, (for instance, when a dispute among Muslim groups arises, standing against the stubborn side that exceeds the limit toward transgression on the other side and refuses to settle the dispute), 2. rejecting injustice and attempting to change it by hand, tongue and/or heart, 3. accepting family responsibility, 4. seeking knowledge, 5. getting cures for diseases, etc. The basic context of the IL is replete with imperatives to maintain the above-mentioned worldly social issues and others. In short, action that follows belief is at the core of the IL. The following Qur'anic Ayat (i.e. verses) and Prophet's sayings highlight the imperative and significance of some of the above IL worldly aspects:

"إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُ بِالْعَدْلِ وَالْإِحْسَانِ وَإِيتَاءِ ذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَيَنْهَىٰ عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ وَالْبَغْيِ يَعِظُكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَذَكَّرُونَ"

Indeed, Allah orders justice and good conduct and giving to relatives and forbids immorality and bad conduct and oppression. He admonishes you that perhaps you will be reminded. (Surah no. 16: verse no. 90; henceforth 16: 90 and all translations are from The Qur'an)

وَإِنْ طَائِفَتَانِ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ اقْتَتَلُوا فَأَصْلَحُوا بَيْنَهُمَا فَإِنْ بَغَتْ إِحْدَاهُمَا عَلَى الْأُخْرَىٰ فَفَاتِلُوا آلَئِي تَبْغِي حَتَّىٰ تَفِيءَ إِلَىٰ أَمْرِ اللَّهِ فَإِنْ فَاءَتْ فَأَصْلَحُوا بَيْنَهُمَا بِالْعَدْلِ وَأَقْسِطُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُقْسِطِينَ

And if two factions among the believers should fight, then make settlement between the two. But if one of them oppresses the other, then fight against the one that oppresses until it returns to the ordinance of Allah. And if it returns, then make settlement between them in justice and act justly. Indeed, Allah loves those who act justly. (49: 9)

On the authority of Abu Sa'eed al-Khudree (may Allah be pleased with him) who said: I heard the Messenger of Allah, "Whosoever of you sees an evil, let him change it with his hand; and if he is not able to do so, then [let him change it] with his tongue; and if he is not able to do so, then with his heart — and that is the weakest of faith." (Hadith 34)

Narrated `Abdullah bin `Umar: The Prophet said, "Every one of you is a guardian and every one of you is responsible (for his wards). A ruler is a guardian and is responsible (for his subjects); a man is a guardian of his family and responsible (for them); a wife is a guardian of her husband's house and she is responsible (for it), a slave is a guardian of his master's property and is responsible (for that). Beware! All of you are guardians and are responsible (for your wards). (Sahih al-Bukhari 5188)

It is worth mentioning that, in Islam, connection with Allah (SWT) emphasizes the seriousness, responsibility, and significance of life; of people's relations; and of their actions. A Muslim's life is calm but serious at its core. The relationship between the IL and its basic context (that is, the Qur'an and Prophet's Sunnah) underlines this fact. That is to say that the IL derives meaning and significance from its basic context.

Based on al-Attas' conceptualization of the IL, al-Sarory (2014) extended the scope of the IL concept to include all the Qur'anic verses, Prophet's sayings, and key Islamic words and expressions used by Muslims in their daily languages and life affairs to both denote and connote the Islamic worldview in its entirety. He also operationalized the IL as an analytical tool in literary works based on the theorizations of both Izutsu (1964), and al-Attas (1970). In this regard, the IL has two contexts, that is, the basic context (i.e., the Qur'an and Sunnah) and the relational (or fictive) context (i.e. the literary work in which the IL is incorporated). Thus, the Islamic aspects in a literary work may be identified, grouped and classified with reference to the nature of IL in its basic context. The IL use in a fictive context may also be compared to its use in its basic context which maintains both the IL meaning and use as base reference to which any deviation can be spotted.

3. Research Methodology

The paper employs the concept of the Islamic language (IL) as an analytical tool. It finds the IL more sensitive to the novel's nuances in the first place than any other academic route, for the IL use in the novel's context can be laid against its basic use in the Islamic context. Thus, unlike other non-Islamic perspectives, this paper puts the Islamic fictive features in their proper context that consequently gives them their due signification

during the analytical process. Conceptually, the IL drives its meaning from the Islamic context in which it originally exists in both its dimensions introduced above. This context is considered the IL basic context in relation to what is called the relational (or fictive) context in which the IL can be used. In this paper, the IL fictive context, as such, is the context of the novel under study (that is, the context of *The Good Muslim*). With its two dimensions: the spiritual and the worldly, the IL stands out as an analytical tool. With those two dimensions, the Islamic aspects in the fictive context can be identified and their nature as belonging to either dimension would readily be revealed. In this way, during analysis, the IL concept provides a comprehensive picture to the nature of the Islamic aspects in the fictive context under study and facilitates the basic context of those aspects for analytical reference.

To recapitulate, this paper understands and employs the IL in the following sense: IL is a group of key Islamic words and expressions included in Muslims' speech and is necessarily and basically comprehended by its Islamic basic context (i.e. Qur'anic and Sunnah contexts) as opposed to what one can call a relational context in which the IL could be used. Moreover, in this paper, the idea of the IL springs from its use in the fictive context under study. Therefore, it is of utmost importance to observe that the study of the IL in this paper is a study of 'use' and 'context', not of meaning. To put it differently, the idea of the IL is to find out the nature of the used IL rather than what it says in the context-in-use specifically in relation to the novel's main protagonists and their interaction and communication with each other.

At this juncture, it is important to critically review some of the relevant literature carried out upon the novel so that the significance of this paper stands out.

4. Literature Review

Within *The Good Muslim's* context, the communication issue between the two main protagonists, Maya and Sohail, is interpreted by some critics from the perspectives of war, gender, diaspora, and identity discourses. Their positions toward their society have also been approached by highlighting the passive impact of the Islamic background on the protagonists' mentalities and/or resistance to it. These critics view Islam, as

a collective term, either as a personal matter, an obstacle to, or part of, a new identity consciousness, or as indefinite to social change.

From a post-war discourse, Sohail's religious way of life is viewed by Bhatta and Bhul (2024) as an obstacle in Maya's path of struggle for justice after the war. To them, Sohail, "a religious fundamentalist," is trying "to impose a Muslim identity," which is negatively contrasted to "secular humanitarianism" (pp. 56-67). From a gendered perspective, Sen (2022) interprets Sohail's silence—or rather lack of response, when Maya attempts to make him talk about war—as that Sohail "does not have any [stories of 'war' bravery]", because he "cannot bear the burden of performing the gender role of a soldier back from war". She further considers his silence as a 'personal choice' (pp. 194-195).

Hasanat (2017) states out of a diasporic perspective that Maya "defines herself as Bangladeshi first, Muslim second" having no choice but to go on with the nationalist agenda: "the only movement she imagines is that of moving forward with her fight for democracy". Sohail, for her, is torn between both his national and religious identities. More specifically, "Sohail is unable to adapt with double consciousness of the imagined diaspora" (p. 63). She further states that "Sohail's consciousness about an imagined diaspora reshapes itself through the prism of religious ideology, allowing his religious culture to usurp his national culture" (p. 63). As one can observe, for Hasanat, the religious aspect is viewed in relation to identity formation within a diasporic discourse.

Majid and Jalaluddin (2018) probe into the novel through the concepts of 'the secular' and 'the religious' as key concepts to address the existing state of affairs between the novel's main characters, Maya and Sohail, reflecting thereupon the identity politics during the nation-building of Bangladesh after the 1971 Liberation War with West Pakistan. They hold the view that "the silence that exists between siblings is caused by Sohail, who views his sister as different, where in his eyes, she increasingly becomes 'the other'." "For Maya," they proceed, "religion . . . is a disease that infected the Pakistani nation which butchered its sons and daughters in the war" (p. 35). They discuss the novel post-colonially adopting Talal Asad's theorizations which view, as they paraphrase, "the secular as an ideology that

brings together different concepts and practices, and which is neither a break from religion nor a continuity of it" (p. 26). These critics employ 'the secular' and 'the religious' as discursive concepts, establishing thereby that "the meaning of each concept changes as the context and meaning changes, thus making it necessary to reconstruct the ways one studies both the secular and the religious" (p. 31). Aware of the two concepts' problematic nature in the state identity formation, they therefore conclude that the only way out to avoid such a binary opposition and consequently restore social balance is to accept "the merge and mutation of identity" which, for them, is what allows for "the creation of the hybrid, or in the case of the novel, a space of moderation" (p. 39).

One can observe that the above reviewed critics accept what the novel demonstrates about the Islamic aspects as taken for granted. That is to say they never delve into the true nature of the IL that Sohail is portrayed to submissively adopt and then speak. To them, the IL that Sohail speaks is considered, as it is in the novel's fictive context, a representative of Islam, that is to say not just some aspects of Islam. Moreover, Sohail is described, by Hasanat (2017), as "a radical Islamist" and his stance is stated, as a matter of fact, as "religious fanaticism" (pp. 62-63). Such critical speculations of the novel's fictive Islamic aspects tints Islam, in its totality and practicality, as being fanatical. Furthermore, such consideration of the Islamic aspects can be taken to be 'epistemic injustice' which is, as conceptualized by Fricker, 'a wrong done to someone specifically in their capacity as a knower.' (Fricker, 2007 as cited in Sandberg & Colvin, 2020, p. 1587).

From a different position, Swazo (2018) attempts to shed some light on the protagonists' communication issue by bringing some analogy from within the Islamic philosophy. By furnishing a background to two Islamic 9th C philosophical schools: the Mu'tazilite and the Ash'arite, Swazo establishes Sohail's and Maya's positions against, as he states, the Islamic mentality toward the Bangladesh 1971 genocide. For him, both schools represent Islam's stance as they both base their arguments upon the Holy Qur'an. He observes that Sohail represents the position of the "Ash'arite 'subjectivist' (man depends on God's unfathomable will) theology". The Mu'tazilite's position, to him, as he alludes to Maya's stance as it seems, is a bit different though: "the Mu'tazilite [are] rationalis[ts] (man must choose)". However, in the final analysis,

he opines that theodicy in Islam is passive as it contradicts with the justice that both schools attribute to Allah as just, for had Allah were just, he goes on to say, how come that He allowed Muslims to do unjust actions? Consider what he establishes in this regard:

This narrative symbolically represents a contestation of "revelation" and "reason," with one resolution proceeding in the direction of Islamic belief (that of the brother Sohail) and consistent with Islamic theodicy; another resolution proceeding toward rejection of Islam (that of the sister Maya) and consistent with a secular and gendered conception of justice emanating from the critical mind of a "liberated" woman . . . One commits to the primacy of the afterlife, to the promise of Paradise; the other to the primacy of the historical, political present . . . Anam . . . call[s] for a new, rational interrogation of the evidence; for enabling women to speak differently from men about 1971; and for the assertion of a human justice brave enough to indict Allah's justice for the latter's inability to indict crimes against humanity committed "in the name of" Islam. (Swazo, 2018, pp. 280-285)

All the above reviewed critiques pay no attention to the existence of a difference between the Islamic aspects denoting and connoting core Islamic ideas and the fictional characters that are depicted to adhere to them. Fictional characters' understanding and conduct, especially when being extremist: lenient or literal, cannot be taken as evidence of the true nature of the ideas they claim to adopt and apply about Islam as their behavior is subject to prejudice or, at least, misconception on the part of the writer. In close connection with such latter statement, Sandberg and Colvin (2020) report some research to have established that "[t]he link between the broad religious belief system called Islam and the form of contemporary violence called Islamic terrorism has been shown to be tenuous" (p. 1585).

Therefore, lest such IL fictive view as well as its critical speculations taken for granted, this paper takes upon itself to unravel the nature of the IL within the fictive context of the novel *The Good Muslim* in relation to the IL basic context. By doing so, it attempts to investigate the nature of the communication issue between the two main protagonists of the novel: Maya and Sohail, and the impact of the IL upon the said communication.

5. Analysis

5.1 Islamic Language (IL) in The Good Muslim

In the novel The Good Muslim, the Islamic vocabulary (whether they are basic Islamic words or Qur'anic verses and expressions related to those basic words) is plenty in number but is sporadically incorporated in the story's events, generally establishing the Islamic features of the novel's context. This IL vocabulary, as it is manifested in the novel's context, is provided here out of sequence with the repetitions eliminated but indicated as numbers

within parentheses in the following table, Table 1. The IL in the novel is assembled in the table below based on the number of their occurrences beginning with the most repetitive basic word God (51 times) and its related words, then prayer (33 times) and its related words and so on. The related expressions and Qur'anic verses found in the novel's context are then grouped based on their relevance to those basic words in the Islamic context in the corresponding columns.

TABLE 1. IL in the fictive context of the novel The Good Muslim

Key Words (number of their occurrence in the fictive context)	Expressions and some Qur'anic verses related to the key words occurred in the fictive context
God (51 times); Allah (12 times); Almighty (6 times)	-Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Raheem (5 times);
	-in the name of God;
	-La Ilaha Illallah, Muhammad ur Rasul Allah
	-Alhamdulillah (3 times)
	-Alhamdulillah hi rabbil al-ameen
	-thanks be to God
	-Subhan Allah (2 times);
	-innalillah (2 times)
	-inshallah (5 times)
	-May . . . soul rest in peace
	-May God Bless . . .
	-Allah Hafez; Khoda Hafez (3 times)
	-God sees everything
	-God Bless you
	-God be with you
	-by the grace of Allah (2 times)
	-God is Great (4 times)
	-God forgives you (3 times)
	-God offers forgiveness
	-God is merciful
	-lord has prescribed for himself mercy
	-the will of God; God willing; God's will: deference to the will of God;
	-under the watchful eye of the Almighty
	-returning to God
	-a gift from God
	-Allah's hands
	-for God's sake

prayer (33 times); mosque (24 times); pray (10 times); Mecca (6 times); Muezzin (6 times); Praying (5 times); call to prayer (3 times); Azaan (2 times); Ka'bah; Sejda; prostration	-imams
	-the worshippers; the praying men
	-pilgrimage to Mecca; Zamzam (3 times); water from the Well of Zamam
Book (33 times); Qur'an (14 times); verses (2 times); Aytul Kursi (2 times); Surah Yasin	-All that is in the heavens and on Earth
	-Every soul shall taste death
	-”There has come to you from God a light and a Book most lucid. With it, God guides him who conforms to his good pleasure to the paths of tranquillity; He shall lead them from the fields of darkness to the light, by his leave, And he shall guide them to a straight path.”
	-for men who surrender to him, and women who surrender to him. For men who believe, and women who believe
	-Allahu la ilaha illa Huwa, Al-Haiyul-Qaiyum. There is no God but He, the Living, the Self-subsisting, Eternal. La ta'khudhuhu sinatun wa la nawm. No slumber can seize Him, nor sleep.
	-”God wrongs no one, Not even by the weight of an atom”
	-Waalqurani alhakeemi, Innaka lamina almursaleena
Faith (9 times); Belief (2 times)	-There is no God but God
	-There is another life after this one
	-God is greater than your belief
	-appealing to God
	-a gift from God
	-equal before God
Prophet (9 times)	-Abraham may peace and blessings be upon him
	-Abraham peace be upon him
	-God's servant
	-Ashahadullah Muhammadur RasoolAllah
	-messengers of God
Muslim (3 times); pious	-As-Salaam Alaikum (6 times)
	-Walaikum As-Salaam (2 times)
	-the slave Bilal -gambling; hallal and haram
Afterlife (3 times)	-The Day of Judgement
Fast (2 times)	-fast during the month of Ramzaan

It is this IL, in the table above, that Sohail, one of the main novel's protagonists, is depicted to convert to and use (or, as this paper puts it, to speak) in his life after returning from war (i.e. the 1971 Liberation war with West Pakistan). The novel's context introduces Sohail's adoption and assimilation of this IL as follows:

This was how it began. It hurt her [i.e., Maya, Sohail's sister] to remember this, because everything that happened afterwards could be traced to Sohail's first steps towards God, beginning with the Book that she [i.e., Sohail's mother] gave him, that gathered dust on his bookshelf . . . that she read aloud while he ate his breakfast, that he was unable to resist, that

he began to memorise, then understand, then love, that finally fell into his hands as he learned to read, that wove itself into his heart – that led to revelation and his conversion, the alchemy of which none of his loved ones could trace to a single moment, a single gesture. (Anam, 2011, p. 93)

It is crucial to observe that, based on the IL basic context, the IL aspects in the novel's context, listed in the table above, only belong to the IL spiritual dimension. That is to say that they all fall within the belief in the pillars of Islam and Islamic faith. Consequently, this shows that the IL worldly dimension, which entails certain actions and practices incumbent upon a Muslim in life, is completely missing in the IL fictive context. This finding is significant in highlighting the nature of the communication issue between the two siblings as it has detrimental impact on it as will soon be revealed in the discussion below.

6. Discussion

In the novel's (*The Good Muslim*) context, there are two main topical issues, namely 1. the war impact on family and national cause and 2. the issue of the IL, in the sense that it represents the Islamic worldview (i.e. Islam). After the Bangladeshi 1971 Liberation war, each character of the two novel-highlighted characters: Maya and Sohail, lives her/his life in a way unique to her/his thinking. The war impact, of which each had a share, has led them to uphold different ideas as ways of life, each in her/his own way. Consequently, this situation leads them to a communication problem with themselves and others. Along the way, despite Maya's strong interest in her ideas, she attempts to ponder over her brother's ideas but eventually to no avail.

The novel's main protagonist, Maya, has a two-fold concern in almost throughout the novel, that is, the family reunion and the national cause. After the war, the issue of the IL that Sohail learns and speaks strongly interferes with those issues, troubling Maya's mind and life along the way. She thinks that Sohail's new way of life is due to the influence of his wife, Silvi, on him: "she knew that whatever direction her brother might be taking, it would be Silvi who pressed him further along the journey" (Anam, 2011, p. 175). Maya fails to notice and attend to her brother's true trouble for which her mother rebukes her:

'You pushed him', Ammoo was shouting. 'You pushed and you pushed' . . . Did you listen to anything he said, up on that rooftop? Did you listen? No. You mocked him. You turned deaf and mocked him.' (Anam, 2011, p. 252)

Maya escapes her inability to communicate with her brother and to regain his old company by busying herself with her chosen occupation as a traveling doctor in another city: an occupation that readily goes along with her concern to serve the national cause, that is, to help build the new post-war country. After the death of Sohail's wife, Maya thinks that it is high time to reach out to her brother again for a re-communication and family re-union. However, she is totally unaware of the nature of Sohail's IL. She just focuses on an external factor that has made Sohail lead another life. In other words, since the shift cause is human (i.e. Silvi) and removed (i.e. she is now dead), it is then possible, she fancies, to get back her brother via human intervention. However, to her puzzlement, Sohail seems to have already completely chosen his religious way with an obvious religious language jargon. His new language (i.e. his acquired IL) appears to be posing a barrier between their possible reunion and re-communication. Upon return from her self-imposed away-from-home journey, Maya is preoccupied with meeting her brother. It is only through his small son, Zaid, that she is able to meet him. Since her return, Sohail:

had been away, travelling from one jamaat to another . . . without the prospect of seeing him . . . At the prospect of seeing him again, she allowed herself a sliver of hope. A reunion. She would approach him, ask about Zaid . . . See if there was somewhere they could meet, she and her brother . . . [Upon meeting him] he held out his arms to her . . . He kissed her forehead. 'As-Salaam Alaikum,' he said. She clung to him, and slowly, gently, he shifted away. 'Walaikum As-Salaam,' she heard herself reply. 'How are you?' [She asks,] 'I am well, by the grace of Allah' [he replies] . . . 'You know I've come back,' she began. 'Yes, I know.' He knew. (Anam, 2011, pp. 78-82)

As observed, it is Maya who makes efforts to approach her brother, for possible re-communication and comprehension, for a hope of regaining a once warm family life as well as to find a supporter in the national cause which never leaves her thought. To this point in the two siblings' interaction, a language barrier has become evident between them.

As for Sohail, he remains stubbornly silent and passive toward his family as well as Maya's concern which is evidently an IL worldly aspect: the family reunion and the national cause. He neglects his son Zaid, a six-year-old boy, who appears to be in desperate need for his paternal care and affection, especially after the mother's death. This behavior shows that Sohail is unaware of the importance of his own personal worldly affairs. When Maya brings up the suggestion of her taking Zaid to school, Sohail dismisses the idea of the boy's formal schooling by referring to a personal tutoring: "His [i.e. Zaid's] education is continuing in the hands of Sister Khadija" (Anam, 2011, p. 82). His negligence of his son worldly affairs ultimately leads him to lose his son's life in the first place. This behavior, as such, reveals outright violation to the IL basic context, especially its worldly dimension, which decrees, among other things, parents' responsibility for their children: ". . . a man is a guardian of his family and responsible (for them) . . ." (Sahih al-Bukhari 5188). As toward Maya, Sohail knows well his sister's deep interest in the national cause, for he himself has been a university student activist and evidently participated during the war for that matter. But now he leads a religious spiritual life typical of his Islamic group The Congregation of Islam about which Maya is illuminated by her mother:

They called themselves Tablighi Jamaat. The Congregation of Islam . . . Sohail had his own group of followers at the mosque; many men had been led to the way of deen – the way of submission – under his direction. They brought their friends, their errand sons, and Sohail told them what to believe and how to live. He was considered a holy man. (Anam, 2011, pp. 21-22)

The IL fictive context reveals that not only is Sohail's religious life, as it is, restricted to 'what to believe and how to live,' indifferent to his family but also to the national cause which is a critical issue for Maya. Sohail's silent, or passive, reaction to the national cause is made to loom large around his newly acquired language, i.e. the IL which appears to be lacking enough resources that could enable him to extend liaison with his sister in that issue specifically. He appears to have only learned to speak the IL at the spiritual level and now teaches it per se to other people. In other words, Sohail's depicted IL appears to be restricted to a limited vocabulary by lacking the personal, social and

intellectual resources for people's worldly life. In this regard, based on the worldview of Islam as al-Attas (2001:1) puts it, Sohail's IL reserve belongs, as the analysis above shows, to just one dimension, that is, the IL spiritual dimension. Moreover, there is no indication whatsoever in the IL fictive context that Sohail, the one who adopts the IL as a way of life, is aware of an existence of an IL worldly dimension. At the beginning of his inclination toward Islam, Maya tries to draw Sohail's attention to the poor people's situation in the country when a poor man stands in the window of their house begging them for some help. This is clearly a worldly situation, but the IL that Sohail speaks is portrayed as being incapable to cater for. Here, both Maya and Sohail are unaware of the IL worldly dimension. She asks Sohail: "What does your book tell you to do with this man, Bhaiya?". When Sohail gives him some money, Maya comments: "That's it? That's all you're doing? Don't you want to know how the man came to be here?" (Anam, 2011, p. 128). In the IL basic context, there is the Zakat, i.e. giving alms to the poor, but Sohail is unaware of its worldly implication. The Zakat is carried out by the people in authority in society for specific categories of people. In this regard, the Qur'an stipulates:

إِنَّمَا الصَّدَقَاتُ لِلْفُقَرَاءِ وَالْمَسْكِينِ وَالْعَامِلِينَ عَلَيْهَا وَالْمُؤَلَّفَةِ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَفِي الرِّقَابِ وَالْغَارِمِينَ وَفِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَابْنِ السَّبِيلِ ۚ فَرِيضَةً مِّنَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ حَكِيمٌ

Zakah expenditures are only for the poor and for the needy and for those employed to collect [zakah] and for bringing hearts together [for Islam] and for freeing captives [or slaves] and for those in debt and for the cause of Allah and for the [stranded] traveler - an obligation [imposed] by Allah. And Allah is Knowing and Wise (9: 60).

This situation further asserts that the IL worldly dimension is completely missing in the novel's context: a fictive imbalance that conspicuously tints the IL as impractical for worldly affairs. It shows that the IL is merely a psychological way out of sophisticated worldly affairs. In fact, in this regard, Sohail's resort and tenacity to one dimension of the IL is explicitly and closely linked to his own deep personal trouble (i.e., the guilt of killing an innocent man; hence seeking divine salvation); it is narrated that:

He had killed an innocent man. The man was not an enemy, not a soldier. Just someone who had let the wrong word come out of his mouth. There is only one way to be good now. The Book has told him he is good, that it is in his nature to be good. The words have been reclaimed and he swells up with love for the Book. (Anam, 2011, pp. 123-124)

Keeping the IL basic context in mind, such deep calming spiritual relief appears to deprive, and drive away, Sohail from seeing, learning about and considering the other IL dimension which never ignores, but rather stipulates, worldly life. In the Qur'an (i.e. the IL basic context), Allah (SWT) states: *وَابْتَغِ فِيمَا آتَاكَ اللَّهُ الدَّارَ الْآخِرَةَ وَلَا تَنْسَ نَصِيبَكَ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا وَأَحْسِنَ كَمَا أَحْسَنَ اللَّهُ إِلَيْكَ وَلَا تَبْغِ الْفُسَادَ فِي الْأَرْضِ*; إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ الْمُفْسِدِينَ (But seek, through that which Allah has given you, the home of the Hereafter; and [yet], do not forget your share of the world. And do good as Allah has done good to you. And desire not corruption in the land. Indeed, Allah does not like corrupters.) (28: 77). This Qur'anic verse reminds Muslims, among other issues, not to abandon worldly life and not to indulge in corruption. However, Sohail is seen to have chosen just the first part of the verse which stipulates that: 'seek . . . the home of the Hereafter'. Also, Sohail's IL spiritual dimension is further highlighted by his mother when she describes his mission to Maya as a way to relieve people's psychology: 'They brought their friends, their errant sons, and Sohail told them what to believe and how to live. He was considered a holy man' (Anam, 2011, p. 22). This IL spiritual dimension, portrayed, at least through Sohail, is shown to be self-contained with which no one knows how the IL works in a person's worldly life. For Sohail only speaks the IL at the spiritual level while being silent, or rather passive, toward his personal worldly affairs: his son Zaid, his education and his family, let alone public worldly affairs.

As for Maya, she uses political language jargon and firmly believes that the regime that took over after the war has betrayed the country. Practices of injustice against women committed during the war have never been rectified and the criminals are still free. She attempts to address and highlight those crimes to society by writing for a newspaper and by attending political meetings—attempts that, she hopes, would lead up to the application of justice. Due to the grip of this political issue upon her, Maya fails to attend to her brother's trouble upon his return from the war. It is narrated that Sohail:

wants her to be quiet so she can hear the roar in his head, thinking that if she could hear that roar, the roar of uncertainty and the roar of death, she might understand. But she refuses to be quiet for long enough . . . I have committed murder. If he were to tell his sister about the war, this is what he would have to tell her. She wants stories of heroism. She wants him to tell her that he planted bombs under country bridges . . . But he has no story of this kind. She grows angrier and angrier at his silence. (Anam, 2011, pp. 124-125)

Upon learning of his IL, Maya also fails to realize the deep impact of the IL spiritual dimension on her brother. She interprets this change to be due to the influence of his wife, Silvi. In fact, Maya's unconcern to the impact of the IL spiritual dimension on her brother seems to be due to the persistent nationalist agenda for which the war started in the first place with the West Pakistan, that is, to establish a secular state, which, in turn, implies the inefficacy and impracticality of the pre-war political religious agenda. That religious agenda's failure, as it appears, is also evident in Maya's bitter response when she hears the "Dictator"—as she calls him (i.e., the Bangladesh president)—"prais[ing] the importance of regional unity [i.e. with Pakistan, Maya's enemy]. All Muslims are Brothers, he repeated". It is here that Maya's resentment stands out: "she couldn't bear to listen. She switched off the television" (Anam, 2011, p. 42). In fact, this very conviction against the said agenda is so powerful that it had even once gripped Sohail himself upon his return from the war when his mother gave him "the Holy Book":

he shakes his head, because he has come to believe that the Book was part of the problem, before the war, before Bangladesh. Because people were attached to the Book, or their idea of the Book, more than to each other, or to their neighbours, or to their country. They had called themselves revolutionaries, and believed that faith was beneath them, a consolation for simpler, lower minds. Sohail turns his face from the Book and waves his mother away. (Anam, 2011, pp. 92-93)

However, after Sohail's change and due to his IL influence of which some old traces remained deep hidden in Maya since childhood when her mother used to teach her some verses of the Qur'an, Maya begins to recollect upon the IL for a while. Moreover, her mother's illness and her fear of losing

her mother deepen her thought and consideration of the IL spiritual dimension, apparently for hope of its effect in making miracles before which science apparently still stands helpless. Here too, one should notice that, similar to her brother, albeit out of her control as she does not know enough about the IL in its full capacity as a signifier of the worldview of Islam, Maya ponders only on the spiritual dimension of the IL. Therefore, due to her lack of knowledge of the IL worldly dimension, Maya's spiritual moments of IL recollection gradually fade out as they are by themselves undoubtedly and evidently insufficient to provide for a balanced personal as well as public life. To Maya, such an IL, as depicted in the novel's context, is irrelevant to her interest in people's worldly life, especially to the pressing and life-demanding issue for her, that is, the national cause.

Within the IL fictive context, both Maya and Sohail are totally unaware of the IL worldly dimension. In fact, they lack the knowledge of this very crucial IL worldly level in Muslims' lives. Had Maya were equipped with the missing religious knowledge as such, she might have considered the Pakistani regime as an oppressor (i.e., transgressor) whose military action against their fellow Muslims and other innocent civilians is in no uncertain terms outright transgression and non-Islamic in the first place. In this regard, in the IL basic context, and in the course of the confrontation with the enemies, Allah (SWT) stipulates in the Qur'an: "وَلَا تَعْتَدُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ الْمُعْتَدِينَ" "do not transgress, Allah does not like transgressors" (2: 190). This makes it evident that Muslims are strictly commanded not to initiate war unreasonably with the enemies (that is, not to transgress), let alone with fellow Muslims and unarmed civilians. Had Maya were aware of this fact, she might have proceeded with her national cause without unnecessarily rejecting the IL which, in its nature and totality, furnishes the moral and religious valence to stand against, and rightly resist, the oppressors and their injustice even if they were fellow Muslims themselves. She might have been able to communicate with her brother about the national cause. That is to say that she might have underlined her brother's critical lack of knowledge about the IL worldly dimension using the same language (i.e. the IL) that he has chosen to speak, but he, in fact, severely lacks its full crucial religious jargon and power for worldly affairs.

7. Conclusion

This paper unravels the communication issue between the two main protagonists of the novel *The Good Muslim*: Maya and Sohail, in relation to the impact of Islam upon it by employing the concept of the IL as an analytical tool. Existing critical literature are found to have overlooked the Islamic features of the novel. In some critiques, Islam is viewed as a collective term. Some critics consider it as being a source of fanaticism while others treat it as a discursive social element in society identity formation. With connection to the novel, Islam is also viewed as a source of passivity impacting its followers. With the employment of the IL in this paper, the Islamic features are given due treatment by identifying and classifying them before finding out their impact upon the communication issue between the novel's main protagonists. The IL has two contexts: a basic context, which is the Qur'an and Sunnah context, and the relational (or fictive) context, which is the novel's context in which the IL is used. It also has two dimensions: the spiritual dimension and the worldly dimension. The analysis reveals that there is only one IL dimension in the fictive context, that is, the spiritual dimension. This shows that the IL worldly dimension, which exists in the IL basic context, is completely missing in the IL fictive context. With reference to such a finding, it is found that the protagonists' communication issue reaches an impasse due to the absence of the IL worldly dimension. Sohail's ignorance of the worldly dimension of the IL he speaks leads him to neglect his son, Zaid, and family. The consequence is detrimental as not only does he leave his son without schooling, but he also eventually loses his son's life. Also, he is portrayed as silent and passive toward his sister, Maya, and her concern for family reunion and national cause. This indicates that Sohail does not only neglect his family but also his society. Maya attempts to understand her brother's IL but to no avail. His IL, as depicted in the novel, frustrates her as it lacks the worldly dimension that is contained in the IL basic context.

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